

Khwarzim (Kath, now called Biruni) - Birthplace

994 A.D.

In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful, high above all, and may great blessings be on Mohammed, the elected of righteousness and truth. [Biruni begins all of his texts with a praise to God/Allah and Mohammed.]

There exists not many more pleasant cities than in the land of Khwarzim, ruled under the Afrighid Dynasty from the year of 305 forward. However, now yet rumors of upheaval and rebellion are heard throughout. A new, opposing, dynasty is threatening the safety of the Afrighids- may God keep them safe from such dangers.

I have been studying under the great and famous scholar Mansur [full name Abu Nasr Mansur] for all of my time on this earth, and viewing the trade in Khwarzim was a common bliss- the finest spices and silks were the attention of my eyes whenever the outside world could be seen. The likes of astronomy, trigonometry, and the history of the Afrighids were my most-studied and favorite disciplines. Four years ago I remember calculating the precise latitude of Kath on the Earth using only the altitude of the Sun, mathematics, and a few astronomy tools such as an astrolabe.

However, political strife is rampant, and my time in this beautiful city of Kath may be nearing an end. God only knows and I can only hope that Kath becomes a city of peace and trade once again.

Rayy (near modern-day Tehran, Iran) - Fled in Poverty

996 A.D.

In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful, high above all, and may great blessings be on Mohammed, the elected of righteousness and truth. [Biruni begins all of his texts with a praise to God/Allah and Mohammed.]

Unfortunately, the political strife within Kath overcame both my and Mansur's families, forcing myself to flee and leave behind my richest belongings. Now I am impoverished in a city by the sea of Khvalis [the Caspian sea] ruled by wealthy warlords whose sole interests are in trade and conquest. Most institutions of Rayy are closed off, offering only criticism to most scholars that attempt to join, including my own attempts. However, I have found a shining of hope in the form of the astronomer Al-Khujandi, who was [and is] willing to allow my studies. One of these studies included the laws of sines in trigonometry, and many other studies on astronomy allowed me to calculate the latitude of Rayy using an improved method. [Biruni still used an astrolabe and calculated the sun's latitude, but he was more precise in Rayy, so he must have used an improved method that isn't known today.]

Thank God for the opportunity to study under a wealthier scholar in Rayy. Despite of this, Al-Khujandi was not a perfect man, [nobody is?] and his calculation of the obliquity of the ecliptic and the latitude of Rayy was two minutes two short- a deserved, criticized mistake at heart. After going through this journey of suffering from political strife, it appears calm again on the horizon. In reality, rumors of the conqueror Mahmud "Sabukitigin" are let loose among the population in Rayy, and I fear the rumors of a conqueror from the south are true. If I am right and Rayy falls under siege, may God protect me from the dangers that lie ahead...

Gurgan (modern-day Gorgan, Iran) - Under a King

1015 A.D.

In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful, high above all, and may great blessings be on Mohammed, the elected of righteousness and truth. [Biruni begins all of his texts with a praise to God/Allah and Mohammed.]

Mahmud is a ruthless conqueror, and I do respect him for his discipline. However he has forced me to flee once again from Rayy, in ruins, into a couple year's journey to the city of Gurgan. In Gurgan lived the ruthless king Qabus, who despite his tyrannical nature was an excellent scholar and poet. He was much too occupied with his ruling of the coastlands of the Khvalis [Caspian] sea to educate me in my disciplines, however I was permitted to continue my own studies in the libraries of Gurgan. In time Qabus was exiled by conspirators of rebellious nature, when I was forced to leave yet again and escape to my pleasant land of Khwarzim, now ruled under an opposing dynasty to the Afrighids. Sadly, these conspirators executed Qabus in the year of 402 [or 403. Note that this year is in the Islamic calendar, not in the Gregorian calendar, in which the year would be 1012. The dates in the diary titles are Gregorian to make it easier to understand the diary.] *The Chronology of Ancient Nations* is already a well-known book that I have written several years ago in Qabus's hospitality- for this reason I have dedicated it to him.

During my journey to Khwarzim it appeared that a new scholar had risen in the area under the name of Ibn Sina ["Son of Brilliance," where "Ibn" means "Son" and "Sina" is a family name relating to "Brilliant." Ibn Sina was also known as Avicenna in Latin for those in Western Europe. His name's real meaning isn't completely known, however.] This man challenged my intellectual pursuits, which most in my perspective would think corruption, but as a scholar I must be open to all ideas as the Prophet Mohammed was. Thank Allah [God] that I am at peace again in my birthplace, Kath.

Ghazni (in modern-day Afghanistan) - Captured a Scholar Slave 1018 A.D.

In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful, high above all, and may great blessings be on Mohammed, the elected of righteousness and truth. [Biruni begins all of his texts with a praise to God/Allah and Mohammed.]

The pleasant land of Khwarzim is no more. In the past year the conqueror Mahmud of Ghazni, having recently dethroned Mahmud “Sabukitigin” as his son, has pillaged Kath and captured the scholars of Khwarzim as prisoners. I, Ibn Sina, and my teacher Mansur [still alive] were the most intellectual of such scholars. Mahmud’s prisoner caravan was a journey through lands I had never seen before into the capital city of the Ghaznavid Empire, Ghazni. Ghazni is a city of luxury and splendor beyond my imagination at the time. Rumors of a land to the east called India are present within the city, and the rumors say that India has scholars and riches that through conquest made Ghazni what it is today as well as a strange religion called Buddhism, of which I do not know the practices of.

Mahmud is a fierce ruler, as was Qabus of Gurgan, and my time in prison is solemn. But it appears that Mahmud is looking towards even deeper, more mystical regions of India with a will to conquest and power, and I may be forced with other scholars to accompany his travels. As of now, I am slowly gaining Mahmud’s respect and hope to be his court astronomer in the coming years. [He actually gets what he wants for once- being a court astronomer is one of his highest achievements!] On the subject of the health and safety of fellow scholars such as my teacher Mansur and Ibn Sina, may Allah grant them peace, safety, and calm of mind in the coming years. If I am ever forced into the mysterious lands of India, may Allah guide the way through hardship and suffering and provide safety to whatever dangers lie ahead.

Lahore, India (in modern-day Pakistan) - An Open Mind

1023 A.D.

In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful, high above all, and may great blessings be on Mohammed, the elected of righteousness and truth. [Biruni begins all of his texts with a praise to God/Allah and Mohammed.]

Mahmud's caravan was the beginning of conquests throughout the mysterious India that led me not into a land of horrors and chaos, but into a land of beauty, life, and disciplines beyond my imagination. In India there is a city by the name of Lahore, in which all three of these things are present. Despite the ruthless nature of Mahmud, Lahore is a sanctuary for scholars, especially for those who speak Sanskrit, the language of the area of India that Lahore is within. A worse part of my forced travels to India is that Mahmud made myself the court astrologer instead of the court astronomer, a role that does not contribute to science. [Biruni heavily disagreed with mythical astrology and preferred scientifically factual astronomy.] However, this role may have been the single idea keeping my reputation alive, so I remained thankful to Mahmud for this and to Allah for keeping me alive in these fifty years.

India is a fascinating place. A year or two ago, a peaceful valley contained the Nandna [also called Nandana] Fort, in which I was able to study Sanskrit and calculate the latitude there not using the stars, but rather from triangulating [surveying a triangular shape to calculate distances] the mountains. Now I am in the great city of Lahore, in which there exists not just the strange Buddhism but also other religions such as Christianity, Judaism, Hinduism, Zoroastrianism, and more I never knew existed- a scary thought to realize that Islam is not the only religion in this world. However, in Lahore the Indian scholars there believe in amazing disciplines, such as that of large numbers, astronomy, and the mathematics of time and shapes. All of these I plan to record in my book of facts, which will be called Al-Biruni's India. It may be hard to believe that journeys can change not only people, but the world- for there exists no more pleasant cities than the places I have visited!

Epilogue - 2025 A.D.

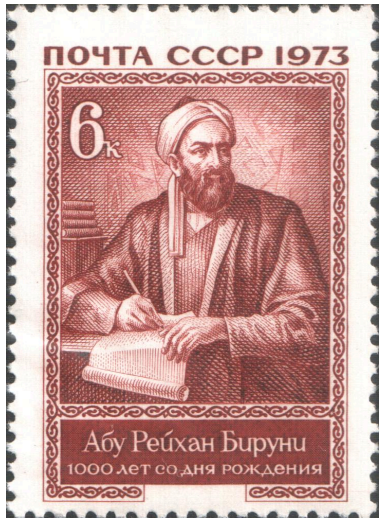
Al-Biruni was likely brought to India by Mahmud because he wanted Biruni's "astrology skills" to help him build "siege weapons," but this is a very vague topic in Al-Biruni's writings, and as of today it isn't known much of why Mahmud brought Biruni to India other than the fact that he was a scholar. After visiting the Indus Valley and Punjab, Mahmud's army continued conquering deeper regions of India near the Indian Ocean with Biruni still in northern parts of India such as Lahore. Biruni followed along with Mahmud's conquests until 1026 A.D., when Mahmud chose to fortify his empire and return to the capital, Ghazni, again with Biruni in tow. Mahmud died after staying a week in Ghazni (In the four year gap he may have fought a few more battles before finally returning to his resting place.) He was buried the same evening he died, on April the 30th, 1030 A.D. at 58 years old.

The eldest son, Mas'ud, succeeded Mahmud, and the rule of the Ghaznavid empire at that time was reported to be great in Biruni's perspective- Mas'ud provided many promotions and goods to Biruni so that he could continue being a scholar. However, in 1040 Mas'ud was murdered and succeeded by his younger brother Mawdud, who was not as kind to Biruni as a ruler. This is the reason that *Alberuni's India* was not dedicated to Mas'ud- because Mawdud would have likely executed Biruni out of spite for his dead older brother. Al-Biruni continued to live in Ghazni for eight more years writing scientific and mathematical works until his death in 1048 A.D. at the old age of 75. The total number of scientific and mathematical books he wrote is impressive- 146- but only 22 of them survive to this day, the most famous one being *Alberuni's India*.

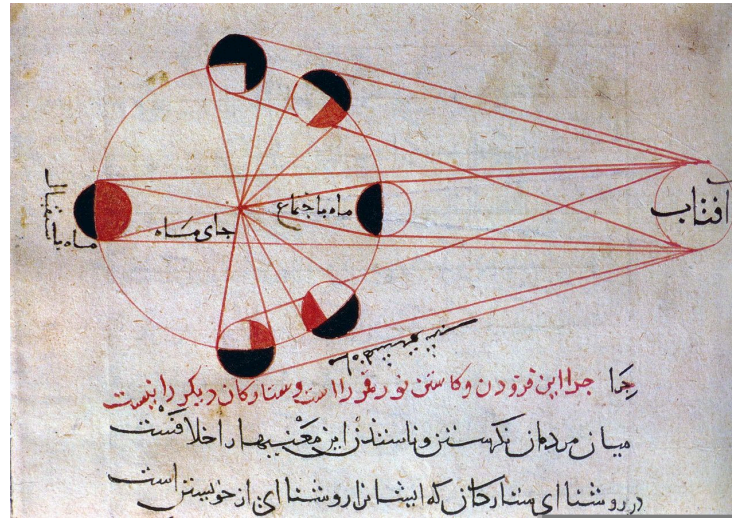
Al-Biruni today is known as one of the world's greatest polymaths, bringing the world (or at least India and the Middle East) through the Dark Ages. Combined with the famous scholar Ibn Sina (known as Avicenna,) these two made a period in history called the "Forgotten Enlightenment." Al-Biruni made more scientific and mathematical contributions to society than most know today- an Islamic scholar that truly made the Dark Ages of our world a golden enlightenment.

Photo Library - 2025 A.D.

Many of you reading this are asking: “Where are the pictures?!” Well, here they are:



A Soviet 1973 postage stamp with an artist rendering of Al-Biruni.



An illustration from one of Al-Biruni's books displaying the various phases of the moon.



A 2012 Google Doodle celebrating Al-Biruni's birthday by showing his fascination with the stars.

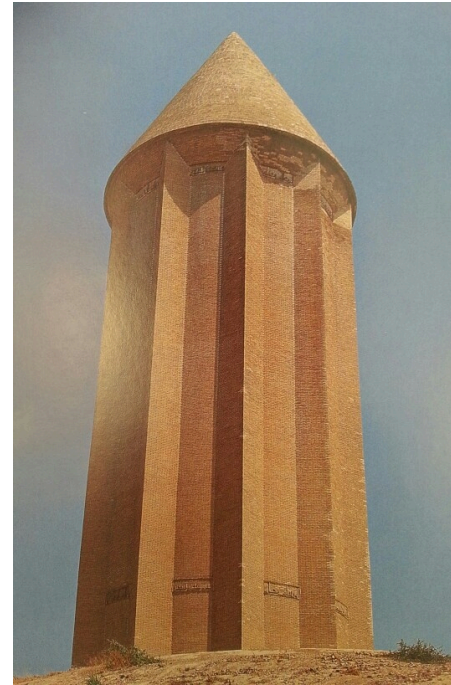
Diary Entries of Al-Biruni (973–1048 CE) – Persian scholar and polymath – by Alexander Friesen



A statue of Al-Biruni at a park in Tehran, Iran.



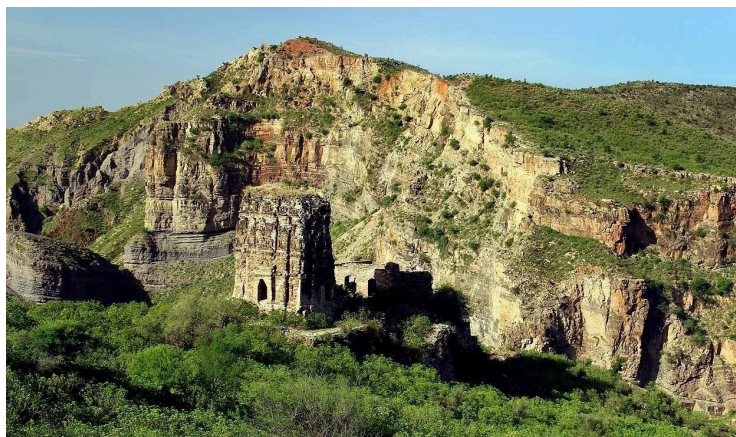
A statue of Al-Biruni holding a globe at the UN Offices in Vienna.



The tomb of Qabus in Gurgan, Iran.



The gate of the Mahmud tomb, moved by British East India Co.



An image of Nandana Fort in the Salt Ranges, due north of Lahore, with the mountains Biruni could have used to triangulate the latitude of Nandana Fort in the background.

To the right ~> is a map showing the extent of the Ghaznavid Empire. The northern tip of the brown area is Kath, where Biruni was born.



Diary Entries of Al-Biruni (973–1048 CE) – Persian scholar and polymath – by Alexander Friesen